

NARCOTICS HUB Drugs and weapons seized by the police in Sri Ganganagar, Rajasthan

RAJASTHAN

UDTA RAJASTHAN, WITH HELP FROM DRONES

The narco trade is evolving dangerously, with drones dropping drugs and arms. A spate of cases shows Rajasthan is a new consumption, manufacturing hub

Early April saw one of the largest air mails so far: 12.167 kg of heroin, in 23 packets, dropped by a large quadcopter into a kinnow orchard in the Karanpur area of Sri Ganganagar. It's a long litany of chases, arrests, hauls worth tens of crores. On April 25, an ANTF operation near Balesar, Jodhpur, even turned into a gunfight. Commandos crawled over 1.5 km to raid an under-construction building that housed an MD lab and came under fire from the rooftop.

It led to the seizure of 176 kg of MD precursors worth about Rs 90 crore. These are not old-style smugglers. "They are armed and organised," says Kumar. In every way. In Barmer, a 5 kg meth stash was linked to a Pakistan-based handler who used digital payments.

Drone data tell the story. The three years up to February 2023 had recorded 28 drone recovery incidents along the India-Pakistan border. By 2024, that had jumped to 179 in a single year. Rajasthan's share is rising. From virtually zero before 2023, the state saw 15 drone drops in 2024. In 2026, it has already touched at least 10. NDPS cases have climbed from 123 in 2023 to 1,604 in 2024, 2,069 in 2025—and 2,558 in just the first four months of 2026! Kumar says the ANTF has carried out nearly 300 raids in the past six months, seizing drugs worth over Rs 600 crore.

Takeaways

- **Police make dramatic seizures of drugs, arms dropped via drones**
- **The long border with Pakistan raises worries of possible terror links**
- **Rajasthan now makes, distributes, consumes premium designer drugs**

The western frontier is only one piece of a larger grid. Even consignments from the Golden Triangle on the east are washing up here. That's not counting what's getting 'Made in Rajasthan'—33 labs for MD were busted recently, mostly makeshift units in the Jodhpur-Jalore-Barmer rural belt that turn precursors sourced from industrial supply chains in Gujarat and Maharashtra into MD within 24-48 hours. The profits have pulled in chemists, transporters and local operatives across states, with old liquor smuggling routes doubling up as narco channels.

Prohibitory changes in the law and in social attitudes are actually pushing users towards synthetics. The ban on poppy husk, once sold through licensed shops, and tighter enforcement around cannabis have reduced access to traditional, lower-potency intoxicants. The effect: a rather more vicious circle. ■